

Harlem Renaissance Library Session

PreK–Kindergarten

PREK–K

25 MINUTES

WHOLE GROUP + TABLE ACTIVITY

SESSION GOALS

Children will: meet Aaron Douglas's art and hear its story; understand that music, painting, and stories are ways people share who they are; practise observing pictures carefully; and create a simple response drawing. Language goals: *silhouette, music, story, colour, Harlem*.

PREPARATION

- Display: large-format print of Aaron Douglas's *Song of the Towers* (or project from exhibition link)
- Tables set: one Green Activity Card per child, crayons, black marker
- Optional read-aloud: *The Watcher* by Nikki Jones or *Duke Ellington* by Andrea Davis Pinkney

SESSION FLOW

- 0–3 min** **Gathering:** Children sit on the rug. *"Today we're going to look at a very special painting and listen to some music that was made a long, long time ago in a place called Harlem, New York. I'm going to play some music — I want you to close your eyes and tell me what colour it sounds like."* Play 20 seconds of jazz. Take 3–4 colour responses.
- 3–8 min** **Picture Walk:** Reveal the Douglas print. *"What do you see? Find the people. What are they doing? What shapes do you notice in the background? Why do you think the artist made the people dark like shadows?"* Accept all responses. Introduce: *"These shadow-shapes are called silhouettes. The artist chose not to show faces — because these people could be anyone. They could be you."*
- 8–13 min** **Read-Aloud or Music Listen:** Read one picture book about Harlem Renaissance (Ellington or Hughes titles work well) OR play a second piece of jazz and ask children to move their hands like the music. Connect: *"The people in the painting were listening to music just like this. They were making something beautiful."*
- 13–22 min** **Activity Card:** Children move to tables. Each child has a Green Activity Card. They draw a silhouette person doing something they love — music, dancing, reading, building — and colour the background in their "music colour." Circulate: *"Tell me about your person. What are they doing? Why that colour?"*
- 22–25 min** **Share and Close:** Three children show their drawing to the group. *"You've just done what Aaron Douglas did — you made a picture that tells a story without showing a face. That makes your person everyone."* Return to classrooms with drawings.

Mini Museum Connection

Option 1 — Visit the Exhibition: Bring your class to experience the phonograph, the Great Migration Map, the Jazz Lab, and more. Ask your librarian to arrange a visit. **Option 2 — Virtual Visit:** minimuseumproject.com/exhibitions/harlem-renaissance

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BOOK RECOMMENDATIONS

Primary Picks

- *Duke Ellington: The Piano Prince and His Orchestra* — Andrea Davis Pinkney (1998) — Caldecott Honor; introduces jazz biography accessibly
- *The Watcher* — Nikki Jones — beautiful introduction to Harlem childhood
- *Ruth and the Green Book* — Calvin Alexander Ramsey — Great Migration through a child's eyes
- *Before She Was Harriet* — Lesa Cline-Ransome — silhouette illustration style directly echoes Douglas

Display and Extension

- Any Langston Hughes picture-book adaptations (several exist for young readers)
- *Harlem* — Walter Dean Myers / Christopher Myers (1997)
- *Stompin' at the Savoy* — by the children — a class writing project you could initiate from this session
- Print: Aaron Douglas postcards or posters from the Schomburg Center (free high-res downloads available)

VOCABULARY FOR EARLY LEARNERS

Silhouette — a shape that looks like a shadow; Aaron Douglas made people look like this in his paintings

Jazz — a kind of music born in America that uses many instruments at once and lets musicians make up parts as they play

Harlem — a neighbourhood in New York City where many Black artists, musicians, and writers lived and worked in the 1920s

Renaissance — a time when lots of beautiful, important things are created all at once (tell children: "like when a garden blooms all at once in spring")

CROSS-CURRICULAR INTEGRATION NOTES

- **Classroom connection:** Share drawings with the classroom teacher as a provocation for discussion about "making something beautiful" and what stories images can tell
- **Music class:** Send the jazz clip recommendation to the music teacher — can be revisited in music with more structured listening
- **Catholic context:** "Every person in Aaron Douglas's paintings is a shadow — but every shadow also has a light behind it. That light is the light of God in every person."